Last Name Data From the 2020 Census

2020 Census Briefs

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INTRODUCTION

Frequently Occurring Last Names in the 2020 Census is the fifth U.S. Census Bureau data product listing the most common last names reported in the decennial census. A 1909 report (Bureau of the Census 1909) provided extensive data on "surnames of the white population" tabulated in the 1790 Census. The modern series of data releases began with the 1990 Census, but the 1990 data tables were based on results from the post-enumeration survey rather than the census itself (U.S. Census Bureau, 1995). The 2000 product used full census results and applied very different methods from the 1990 release (Word et al., 2007). The 2000 methodology was revised for the 2010 product (Comenetz, 2016) and further revised and expanded for 2020. This document first summarizes the methodological changes between 2010 and 2020, then describes the 2020 results and compares them with data from previous decades.[1]

[1] This brief describes the overall frequency of last names, as well as some of the basic demographic characteristics that are associated with last names. The presentation of data in this brief focuses on summarized aggregates of counts and characteristics associated with names, and the data do not in any way identify specific individuals. Data on first and last names are always tabulated separately.

Names data tables provide data on the frequency of individual names. They are not suitable for producing aggregate statistics such as the total U.S. population of a given race or Hispanic origin group. Names data are subject to error arising from nonresponse.

The public last name data table includes more than 156,000 last names with a frequency of 100 or more in the 2020 Census. A subset of the full table, with the top 1,000 most frequent last names, is also available.

The term "predominantly" is used where the majority of the people with the listed names identified with a single race, Hispanic origin, or sex category. For example, "Garcia" is a predominantly Hispanic last name because 91 percent of the people named Garcia chose Hispanic in their response to the 2020 Census.

The Census Bureau has reviewed this data product to ensure appropriate access, use, and disclosure avoidance protection of the confidential source data used to produce this product. Disclosure Review Board (DRB) approval number: CBDRB-FY26-058.

METHODOLOGY

The 2020 last name project used the programming and methods from 2010 as a starting point. Edits and corrections from 2000 and 2010 were also applied in 2020. Names data from each census contain different quality issues, and an extensive review led to an expansion of the set of edits and corrections. This section includes a description of ways in which the 2020 methods differed from the previous methodology that is described in Word et al. (2007) and Comenetz (2016).

The 2020, 2010, and 2000 names products use the same six Hispanic origin and race categories: Non-Hispanic White alone, Non-Hispanic Black or African American alone, Non-Hispanic American Indian and Alaska Native alone, Non-Hispanic Asian and Native Hawaiian and Other Pacific Islander alone, Non-Hispanic Two or More Races, and Hispanic or Latino origin.[2]

Creation of the 2020 product started with raw data from the 2020 Census—the last names provided by census respondents. The raw 2020 names list was extensively reviewed by a group of Census Bureau staff. The most time-consuming review was manual ("eyeball") scanning of last names with a frequency of 10 or more, about 950,000 names. Team findings were consolidated into a new set of edits, comprising

This brief is released to inform interested parties of ongoing research and to encourage discussion of work in progress. Any views expressed are those of the author and not necessarily those of the U.S. Census Bureau.

[2] In the rest of this brief, White is used interchangeably with Non-Hispanic White alone; Black is used interchangeably with Non-Hispanic Black or African American alone; Hispanic is used interchangeably with Hispanic or Latino origin; Asian and Native Hawaiian and Other Pacific Islander is used interchangeably with Non-Hispanic Asian and Native Hawaiian and Other Pacific Islander alone.

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updates or corrections needed to fix problems that arose in 2020 but not in 2010, or to fix problems that were partially addressed in the 2010 programming but were more widespread or complex in the 2020 dataset. New programming, to add to the 2010 programs, was written to implement the new set of edits. Revised output was checked to determine if all edits were successfully addressed, and also compared with the 2010 product to determine if changes in name frequency (name count, or number of times each name was reported in the census) over the decade tracked general demographic trends.

Programming and reviews provided a more accurate last name dataset, edited for consistency and omitting nonname text (examples provided in the next paragraph). Two further edits were applied to ensure the confidentiality of individual census data in the public names tables. First, the 2020 last names data were limited to names also found in the 2010 Census Names Table that had a frequency of at least 100 in both years. Second, the data entered the Census Bureau's disclosure avoidance process for noise infusion. Noise was infused into the race and Hispanic origin data. Total counts (total name frequencies) and proportions were calculated from noisy race and Hispanic origin data; noise was not separately infused into the calculated data.

The noise added to the counts of last name by race and Hispanic origin has at least a 95 percent probability of falling between ± 2. For example, if the true 2020 Census count of people of Hispanic origin named SAMPLENAME is 1,000, then there is at least a 95 percent chance that the noise-infused value appearing in the public last name table will be between 998 and 1,002. Therefore, noise infusion should have a small relative effect on the vast majority of name counts in this table. Also, because of noise infusion, the public names tables contain a few names with total frequencies below 100, that is, where the sum of noise-infused race and Hispanic origin counts ended up under 100.

After noise infusion, an optimization procedure was applied to ensure no negative counts would appear in the final data. However, the original noisy data, including negative counts, are also available for research purposes.

2020 and Previous Edits

Processing of 2020 Census names data incorporated all edits and deletions applied in 2010 and 2000 (Comenetz, 2016). These edits included removal of all punctuation marks, numbers, and spaces; deletion of suffixes such as JR, SR, III, and THIRD; and correction of some obvious spelling errors in common names. Therefore, SMITH, S M I T H, SMITHJR, and SMITH III are all counted as SMITH.

Deletions carried over from 2010 included single-letter entries, most two-letter entries, and many obvious nonnames such as ABCDEFG, ADULT FEMALE, DONT KNOW, and NO NOMBRE. Names that looked improbable but not impossible were kept, e.g., ANONYMOUS.

The primary problem identified by reviewers in the raw 2020 data was the proliferation of generic words (e.g., PERSON) and number words (TWENTY-TWO) listed as names or parts of name entries. Most review and programming effort was devoted to finding and deleting generic word entries, and modifying entries that included both an actual name and generic words.

Reviewers also noted that in Spanish names containing Ñ, the Ñ was converted to ?. For example, PEÑA became PE?A. Any symbols other than the standard 26 English letters are omitted in the names tables, so in these cases, ? was corrected to N—becoming PENA in this example.

Generic and Nonname Edits

More than 1 million last name entries in the raw 2020 Census results either consisted of generic words or included generic words along with an actual name. If not removed or edited, several generic words, such as PERSON, would have been among the highest-frequency names shown in the final products.

Besides PERSON, generic words most commonly described family status (CHILD, DAUGHTER, GRANDSON), personal characteristics (ELDERLY, FEMALE, MALE, SINGLE, STUDENT), and residential status (RESIDENT, TENANT, HOUSEHOLDER). Some name entries combined generic terms and real names, as in MRS SMITH.

Another large category of generic entries were those containing numbers spelled out as words, or generic terms combined with numbers. Examples include EIGHTEEN, TWENTY-TWO, CHILD 2, PERSON FIVE, and PERSONA DOS.

Removal of generic terms is inherently imperfect because some generic terms are also real first or last names—for example, BABY, CHILD, PERSON, SON, and YOUNG. In ambiguous cases,

names were left unedited. Also, some words were considered generic if they appeared as a first name but not as a last name, or vice versa. For example, CHILD was a very common generic first name entry, is rarely a real first name, but is also a common real last name. This determination was supported in some cases by reference to the Social Security Administration's baby name counts covering the past century (Social Security Administration, 2025).

Many entries containing versions of JOHN DOE and JANE DOE were deleted from the names datasets. Simple entries with JOHN or JANE as the first name and DOE as the last name were not deleted because these can be real names. Therefore, the frequency of DOE listed in the last name table is likely inflated. However, this inflation was substantially mitigated by the deletion of any entry that was clearly generic, such as JOHN DOE #2, DOE 4, and BABY DOE.

In addition to generics, over 700 nonname words or word combinations were added to the delete list. These included, for example, several misspellings of UNKNOWN.

Time and budget limitations also prevented manual review of every name. Therefore, the final name tables do contain some generic and nonname terms, and counts of real names that can also be generic may be inflated—especially where, as with PERSON, the generic term was common in 2020 results. Nevertheless, results suggest that edit procedures eliminated the vast majority (more than 95 percent) of nonname entries.

SUMMARY OF RESULTS

Table 1 outlines the national distribution of last names by frequency in the United States in the 2020 Census. The unedited census results contained about 9.4 million unique last names reported by census respondents in 2020. Editing removed about 1.6 million of these, and revised millions more as described in this brief, leaving 7.8 million different last names. Of these, 11 were reported more than a million times each, while over 7 million, or 98 percent, were reported fewer than 100 times. Many of the latter were unique last names or unique variations of more frequent names, including errors resulting from the transcription of names handwritten on census forms. After editing, last names were recorded for 299 million people, or 90.2 percent of the population enumerated in the 2020 Census.

The public last name data tables provide frequency, rank, and distribution by Hispanic origin and race groups. The top five last names were the same in 2020, 2010, and 2000 (SMITH, JOHNSON, WILLIAMS, BROWN, and JONES). Below the top five, the most notable change from 2000 to 2020 is the increasing prominence of predominantly Hispanic last names. In 2000, the top 50 contained ten last names that were at least 90 percent Hispanic, and the top-ranked Hispanic last name (GARCIA) was ranked eighth. In 2020, 13 of the top 50 were at least 90 percent Hispanic, and GARCIA was ranked sixth.

The next two tables look only at the 1,000 most frequent last names. Table 2 shows the ten names with the highest shares of identification with each Hispanic origin or race group. For example, 86.2 percent of people with the name PIERRE are Black. There is little overlap among the six lists, highlighting the degree to which last names vary among racial and ethnic groups in the United States.

Table 1.
Last Names by Frequency Range and Number of People: 2020

Frequency range	Last names			People with these last names		
	Number	Cumulative number	Cumulative proportion (percent)	Number	Cumulative number	Cumulative proportion (percent)
1,000,000+	11	11	0.0	15,051,331	15,051,331	5.0
100,000–999,999	299	310	0.0	65,386,440	80,437,771	26.9
10,000–99,999	3,184	3,483	0.0	81,939,610	162,377,381	54.3
1,000–9,999	22,634	25,818	0.3	61,614,356	223,991,737	74.9
100–999	133,370	156,004	2.0	38,589,433	262,581,170	87.8
1–99	7,609,574	7,765,578	100.0	36,317,061	298,898,231	100.0

Source: U.S. Census Bureau, 2020 Census.

Table 2.

Last Names With the Largest Share in Each Hispanic Origin and Race Group: 2020

Last name	Rank among all last names	Frequency	Occurrences per 100,000 people	Percent in this group
Non-Hispanic White Alone				
YODER	508	64,632	21.6	96.7
FRIEDMAN	898	38,252	12.8	94.0
SCHWARTZ	344	88,948	29.8	93.7
WEISS	588	55,845	18.7	93.0
KRUEGER	968	35,568	11.9	93.0
SCHMITT	988	34,747	11.6	92.9
KLEIN	398	79,552	26.6	92.9
MUELLER	530	62,147	20.8	92.9
SCHROEDER	502	65,286	21.8	92.7
SCHNEIDER	320	97,428	32.6	92.7
Non-Hispanic Black or African American Alone				
PIERRE	876	39,005	13.0	86.2
WASHINGTON	148	172,075	57.6	83.6
JEFFERSON	615	53,646	17.9	71.6
MOHAMED	827	40,957	13.7	67.7
BOOKER	965	35,648	11.9	62.7
JOSEPH	283	108,935	36.4	55.5
CHARLES	526	62,686	21.0	55.2
BANKS	297	103,658	34.7	52.6
JACKSON	20	686,937	229.8	51.2
MOSLEY	744	45,562	15.2	50.9
Non-Hispanic Asian and Native Hawaiian and Other Pacific Islander Alone				
XIONG	750	45,183	15.1	97.3
ZHENG	781	43,117	14.4	97.1
ZHU	966	35,639	11.9	96.6
ZHAO	877	38,974	13.0	96.6
VANG	582	56,261	18.8	96.4
KAUR	431	75,046	25.1	96.3
ZHOU	871	39,160	13.1	96.3
XU	763	44,406	14.9	96.2
ZHANG	252	122,053	40.8	96.2
HUANG	314	98,330	32.9	96.2
Non-Hispanic American Indian and Alaska Native Alone				
JOHN	919	37,363	12.5	9.6
LOWERY	832	40,645	13.6	4.0
HUNT	173	152,764	51.1	3.7
SAMPSON	913	37,721	12.6	3.4
JACOBS	266	114,905	38.4	3.3
MOSES	888	38,468	12.9	3.1
LUCERO	885	38,613	12.9	2.9
ASHLEY	941	36,420	12.2	2.5
JAMES	86	243,502	81.5	2.4
FRANK	516	63,608	21.3	2.2
Non-Hispanic Two or More Races				
WASHINGTON	148	172,075	57.6	6.0
WONG	271	112,062	37.5	6.0
BOOKER	965	35,648	11.9	6.0
JEFFERSON	615	53,646	17.9	5.7
BANKS	297	103,658	34.7	5.7
MOSLEY	744	45,562	15.2	5.7
GAINES	791	42,617	14.3	5.6
WARE	695	47,874	16.0	5.6
BLACKWELL	759	44,711	15.0	5.5
DORSEY	804	41,699	14.0	5.5

Notes available at end of table.

Table 2.
Last Names With the Largest Share in Each Hispanic Origin and Race Group: 2020—Con.

Last name	Rank among all last names	Frequency	Occurrences per 100,000 people	Percent in this group
Hispanic or Latino Origin				
BARAJAS	777	43,327	14.5	95.7
VELAZQUEZ	501	65,353	21.9	95.2
AVALOS	944	36,305	12.1	95.2
ZAVALA	654	50,789	17.0	95.1
VAZQUEZ	191	143,372	48.0	95.1
OROZCO	500	65,402	21.9	94.9
JUAREZ	315	97,719	32.7	94.8
HUERTA	747	45,314	15.2	94.8
TREJO	850	39,769	13.3	94.8
MAGANA	922	37,335	12.5	94.7

Note: Table limited to last names that were among the top 1,000 by total frequency in 2020.
Source: U.S. Census Bureau, 2020 Census.

Table 3.
Fastest-Growing Last Names: 2010 to 2020

Last name	Frequency in 2010	Frequency in 2020	Non-Hispanic or Latino					Hispanic or Latino origin	Change in frequency (percent)
			White alone	Black or African American alone	American Indian and Alaska Native alone	Asian and Native Hawaiian and Other Pacific Islander alone	Two or More Races		
ZHANG	70,125	122,053	2.4	0.5	0.0	96.2	0.6	0.3	74.1
LIU	78,370	127,257	2.3	0.4	0.0	95.3	1.4	0.6	62.4
WANG	109,883	169,987	3.2	0.5	0.0	94.6	1.4	0.4	54.7
AHMED	48,319	74,458	16.7	25.4	0.2	52.8	3.6	1.3	54.1
KAUR	48,753	75,046	1.6	0.4	0.5	96.3	0.8	0.3	53.9
LI	111,786	165,790	2.1	0.5	0.0	96.0	0.9	0.5	48.3
LIN	79,508	116,776	2.0	0.3	0.0	95.7	1.4	0.5	46.9
ALI	60,002	84,529	18.8	31.5	0.4	41.8	4.9	2.6	40.9
SINGH	116,749	163,612	4.7	3.5	0.9	85.3	3.4	2.3	40.1
CHEN	169,580	233,798	2.1	0.4	0.0	95.4	1.5	0.6	37.9
WU	71,721	97,527	2.2	0.3	0.0	95.4	1.5	0.6	36.0
HUANG	72,328	98,330	1.9	0.3	0.0	96.2	1.2	0.4	36.0
PATEL	229,973	309,327	3.0	0.6	0.6	93.8	1.6	0.5	34.5
KHAN	76,171	101,770	5.5	3.1	0.4	83.6	5.2	2.2	33.6
SHAH	58,287	76,855	3.4	0.8	0.3	91.8	2.9	0.8	31.9

Note: Hispanic origin and race percent distribution is from the 2020 Census. Table limited to last names that were among the top 1,000 by total frequency in both 2010 and 2020.
Source: U.S. Census Bureau, 2020 Census.

Most individual last names do not reflect the diversity of the population as a whole. In many cases, over 90 percent of people reporting a name identify with just one of the six Hispanic origin or race groups. In contrast, few last names are equally common in multiple Hispanic origin or race groups.

Table 3 shows the 15 most rapidly increasing last names that were among the top 1,000 in both 2010 and 2020, along with their Hispanic origin and race group characteristics. All 15 are predominantly Asian and Native Hawaiian and Other Pacific Islander, except for ALI, a name with exceptionally broad Hispanic origin and race diversity. This pattern reflects national population change between 2010 and 2020, when the Asian and Native Hawaiian and Other Pacific Islander population increased more rapidly than the population as a whole. Note that the rate of coverage—percentage of the population for whom last names were gathered—was a few percentage points lower in 2020 than in 2010 (compare Table 1 in this brief, Table 1 in Comenetz (2016), and the total national census counts from 2010 and 2020). Therefore, true name growth rates were likely higher than what is shown in Table 3.

Recent geographically diverse immigration might be expected to increase, rather than decrease, last-name diversity, leading to a rapid decline in the share of the population that has one of the most common names. However, this has not happened because most immigration is from Asia and Latin America, and the Hispanic and Asian and Native Hawaiian and Other Pacific Islander populations have last names that are less diverse than the U.S. average. For the population as a whole in 2020, the ten most frequent last names accounted for 4.7 percent of the population (Table 4), compared to 4.9 percent in 2010, while to cover one-quarter of the total population required only 258 last names, compared to 239 in 2010.

The White population was more diverse than the national average in this respect, but in other groups, the most common last names were reported by a larger share of the population. The highest level of clustering is found in the Hispanic population, where just 35 last names cover one-quarter of the population, and 14.2 percent of people reported one of the top ten names. A similar pattern was seen for the Asian and Native Hawaiian and Other Pacific Islander population and for the Black population.

The first U.S. census was taken in 1790. In 2020, the national population was more than 80 times as large as it was in 1790. Despite 230 years of population growth and immigration from around the world, the 2020 Census list of most frequent last names contains many of the same names as in 1790.

Table 4.
Last Name Clustering by Hispanic Origin and Race Groups: 2020

Group	Group covered by top ten last names (percent)	Last names needed to cover 25 percent of group (number)
Total population	4.7	258
White alone	4.4	334
Black alone	12.2	50
American Indian and Alaska Native alone	6.3	160
Asian and Native Hawaiian and Other Pacific Islander alone	12.9	45
Two or More Races	6.1	192
Hispanic or Latino origin	14.2	35

Source: U.S. Census Bureau, 2020 Census.

Figure 1 shows the 15 most common last names recorded in 1790, 1990, 2000, 2010, and 2020. SMITH occupies the top rank every year, and eight of the top 15 last names appear in all five lists. The primary change is the addition of several predominantly Hispanic names starting in 2000.

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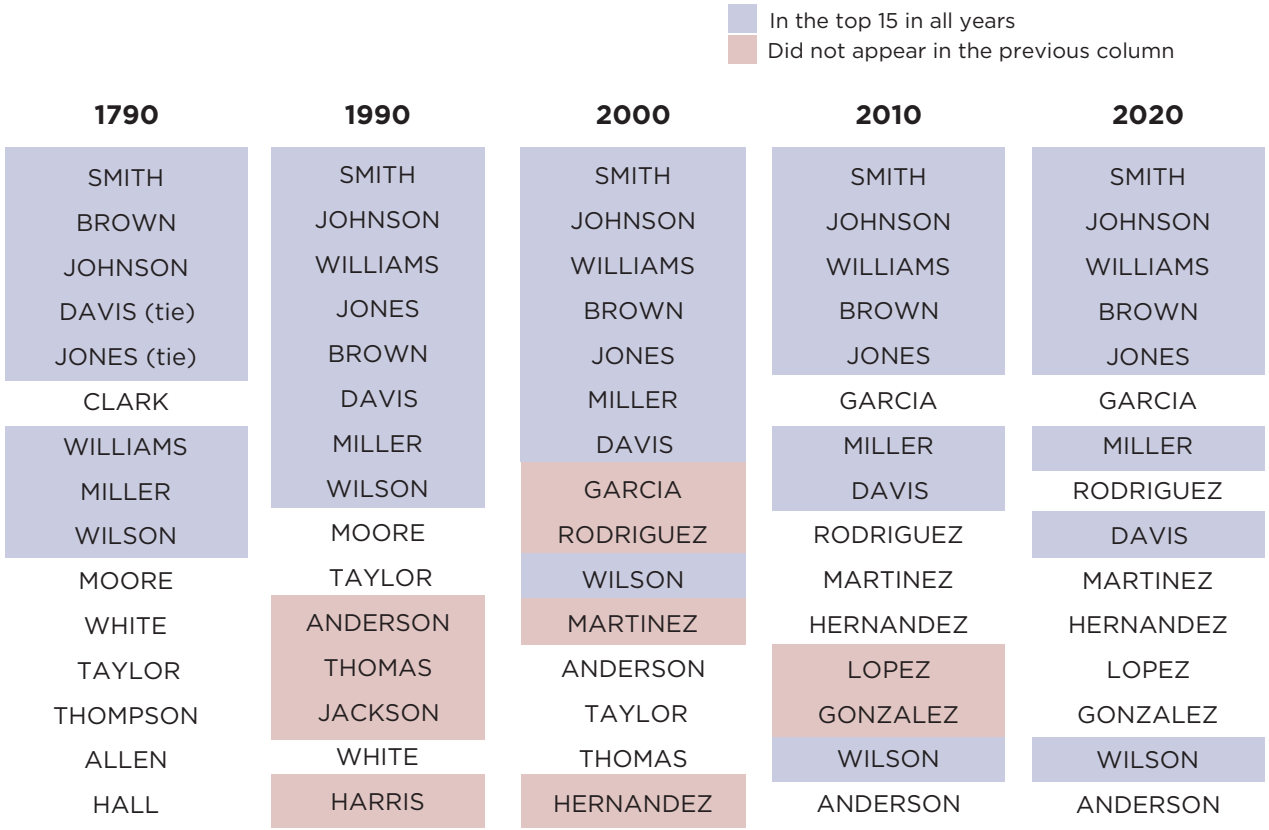
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Figure 1.
Top 15 Last Names Since 1790 by Rank



Note: The methods for obtaining names frequencies were similar for the 2000, 2010, and 2020 Censuses. The 1990 data were derived from the Post-Enumeration Survey rather than the census itself. Data from 1790 are for the White population only, and counts include groups of similar names. For example, the SMITH count includes SCHMIDT, SMYTH, and six other names.
Source: 1790: Bureau of the Census (1909), 1990: U.S. Census Bureau (1995), 2000: Word et al. (2007), 2010: Comenetz (2016), 2020: U.S. Census Bureau, 2020 Census.

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